

TRANSVERBERATION OF ST TERESA OF AVILA

	The transverberation of St. Teresa of Ávila is a mystical experience where an angel pierced her heart with a fiery golden spear, symbolizing an overwhelming union with God's love. [1, 2] The Vision • The Angel: St. Teresa described seeing a small, highly beautiful angel on her left side with a face that burned like fire, identifying him as a seraph or cherub. [1, 2] • The Dart: The angel held a long golden spear or dart with a small flame at the tip, which he thrust into her heart several times to pierce her deepest entrails. [1, 2] • The Sensation: When withdrawn, she felt as though her entrails were pulled out with it, leaving her entirely on fire with the love of God. [1] • The Pain: She noted the intense pain was spiritual rather than purely physical, and it was so sweet she wished it to never end. [1, 2]
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Significance and Legacy

- **Feast Day:** The Discalced Carmelites celebrate the feast of the Transverberation of St. Teresa on August 26.
- **Autobiography:** St. Teresa documented this central event in her spiritual journey

The transverberation of Saint Teresa of Ávila—a mystical experience where her heart was symbolically pierced by an angel's spear—profoundly transformed her spiritual and psychological state.

Key Transformations

- **Fearlessness:** She lost her intense dread of divine judgment and physical suffering.
- **Fortitude:** The experience gave her the strength to endure severe illness and chronic pain.
- **Defiance:** She successfully resisted intense opposition from church authorities who doubted her visions.
- **Action:** It catalyzed her reform of the Carmelite Order, leading her to found 17 new convents across Spain.

Sharon’s reflection – haven’t picked up all the points – these notes are the ones I picked up:

- In silence , she feels His presence
- Flame at the end of the dart – what’s the significance
 - Fire is the work of the Father to bring His people back to him as with the FIRE of Elijah
 - Jesus said, I come to set the world on FIRE
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- Properties oi FIRE
 - Purifies – move you to look at your sins; SEE BELOW:
 - Refines - SEE BELOW
 - Melts – and turn to dust / melts and combines – will transform
 - We burned and turn to dust; surrender to the creator as we are nothing
 - We are to be beacons of light; to be the light of the world
 - Allow ourselves to be transformed
 - Let HIM run your LIFE; not your DESIRES
 - Darts – it pierces, it wounds
 - Cooks food

Allow God to use you.

I am yours; YOU are mine. What do you ask of me?

• **HOW DOES FIRE REFINES US:**

Fire refines us by using difficult trials and hardships as a controlled heat that burns away our emotional, moral, and spiritual impurities. [1, 2]
Based on the traditional metaphor of a refiner purifying precious metals like gold and silver, this transformation happens in a few clear stages: [1, 2]

The Process of Refinement

- **Bringing impurities to the surface:** Intense heat melts the metal, causing worthless waste—called dross—to float to the top. In human life, pressure and hardship expose hidden flaws, pride, fear, or bad habits we did not know we had. [1, 2, 3]
- **Skimming away the waste:** A metal refiner carefully scrapes away the impurities layer by layer. Similarly, life's challenges strip away selfishness and distractions, leaving us stronger and morally cleaner. [1, 2, 3]
- **Controlled by a master:** A refiner never leaves the fire untended or lets the heat become too hot to destroy the metal. The goal of the trial is transformation and strengthening, not destruction. [1, 2, 3]
- **Revealing a clear reflection:** The refiner knows the metal is pure when he can look down and clearly see his own face mirrored on the surface. The final goal of being tested by fire is to reflect patience, wisdom, and character. [1, 2]

HOW DOES FIRE PURIFIES US:

Fire purifies us physically by destroying harmful bacteria and waste, and spiritually by acting as a metaphor for how life's hard tests burn away our inner flaws. [1, 2]

Physical Purification

- **Killing germs:** Extreme heat and boiling water destroy dangerous bacteria and make things safe to use or consume.
- **Cleaning metal:** Intense heat melts raw metal ore. The useless waste, or **dross**, floats to the top so workers can skim it away. [1, 2]

Spiritual and Symbolic Purification

- **The "Refiner's Fire":** Many spiritual traditions use fire as a symbol for personal growth through hardship.
- **Facing trials:** Difficult times act like a hot furnace, putting pressure on our daily lives.
- **Removing faults:** Just like fire brings metal impurities to the surface, tough experiences expose bad habits, pride, or fear so we can let them go.
- **Lasting change:** Enduring these tests helps shape a stronger, wiser, and more patient character. [1, 2, 3, 4, 5]

Elijah’s Major Fire Events:

The Contest on Mount Carmel (1 Kings 18)

- **The Background:** King Ahab and the people of Israel had turned away from God to worship the false god Baal. [1, 2]
 - **The Challenge:** Elijah challenged 450 prophets of Baal to a contest on Mount Carmel. Each side prepared a bull on a wood altar, and the god who answered by consuming the sacrifice with fire would be recognized as the true God. [1, 2]
 - **Baal’s Defeat:** The prophets of Baal prayed all day, but nothing happened. [1, 2]
 - **The Miracle:** Elijah rebuilt the altar with twelve stones, placed the offering on it, and had the people douse it with water three times until the trench around it filled up. Elijah prayed a brief prayer, and the fire of the Lord fell from the sky. It consumed the sacrifice, the wood, the stones, the dust, and the water.[1, 2, 3, 4, 5]
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Other Major Fire Events Involving Elijah

- **Fire on the Soldiers (2 Kings 1):** When King Ahaziah sent groups of fifty soldiers to arrest Elijah, the prophet called down fire from heaven to consume the hostile troops. [1, 2]
 - **The Chariot of Fire (2 Kings 2):** At the end of his earthly ministry, Elijah did not die. Instead, a whirlwind and a [chariot of fire](#) with horses of fire separated him from Elisha, carrying Elijah up into heaven. [1, 2, 3, 4]
 - **The Still Small Voice (1 Kings 19):** While hiding on Mount Horeb, Elijah experienced a great wind, an earthquake, and fire, but God's presence was revealed not in the fire, but in a gentle whisper. [1]
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The Transverberation of St. Teresa of Jesus

Aug 26, 2020

Written By [Fr. Pier Giorgio of Christ the King, O.C.D.](#)

Note: The following homily for the Memorial of the Transverberation of St. Teresa of Jesus was given by Deacon Br. Pier Giorgio of Christ the King, O.C.D., on the occasion of the clothing Mass of a Discalced Carmelite nun.

At the end of May in 1921, St. Teresa Benedicta, then Edith Stein, boarded a train in Göttingen bound for her friend's house in the Southwest of Germany. Prior to embarking, another friend, Pauline Reinach, who later became a Benedictine nun, gave to Edith her copy of St. Teresa's *The Book of Her Life*. Her time in Göttingen had been a bit chaotic, and so this peaceful book must have been a welcome gift. By this time, Edith was perhaps being readied for her conversion, but her experience of the book must have had a significant impact because, within two months of reading it, she wrote to her sister Erna to prepare their mother for her conversion to Catholicism. She later told a priest that it was her experience of reading St. Teresa's *Life* that became the final catalyst for her conversion.



Bernini, Giovanni Lorenzo, "St. Teresa in Ecstasy," Chiesa Santa Maria della Vittoria, Rome, Italy.

In her reading of St. Teresa's *Life*, St. Teresa Benedicta would have encountered our Holy Mother's experience of the Transverberation of her heart in chapter 29. Teresa writes:

The Lord wanted me while in this [paralyzed] state to see sometimes the following vision: I saw close to me toward my left side an angel in bodily form. . . . the angel was not large but small; he was very beautiful and his face was so aflame that he seemed to be all afire. . . . I saw in his hands a large golden dart and at the end of the iron tip there appeared to be a little fire. It seemed to me this angel plunged the dart several times into my heart and that it reached deep within me. When he drew it out, I thought he was carrying off with him the deepest part of me; and he left me all on fire with great love of God. The pain was so great that it made me moan, and the sweetness this greatest pain caused me was so superabundant that there is no desire capable of taking it away; nor is the soul content with less than God. The pain is not bodily but spiritual, although the body doesn't fail to share in some of it, and even a great deal. The loving exchange that takes place between the soul and God is so sweet that I beg Him in His goodness to give a taste of this love to anyone who thinks I am lying.¹

Perhaps it is difficult to imagine this vision with St. Teresa herself. But I think that Edith would have tried to imagine it. In her own philosophical mind, she well understood the phenomenon of empathizing with the experience of others even when we do not directly feel the joy or pain that others feel. She had spent the previous decade of her life reflecting on this process as it occurs in the realm of ordinary life experiences.

But what about extraordinary experiences? In the final paragraph of her dissertation on empathy, written before her conversion, she writes this:

There have been people who thought that in a sudden change of their person they experienced the effect of the grace of God, others who felt themselves to be guided in their conduct by a protective spirit. . . . Who can say whether there is genuine experience present here? . . . Nevertheless, the study of religious consciousness seems to me to be the most appropriate means of answering our question [of empathy], just as, on the other hand, its answer is of most interest for the domain of religion. However, I leave the answering of this question to further investigation and satisfy myself here with a “non liquet,” “It is not clear.”²

So, imagine what her reaction would have been to reading St. Teresa’s mystical experience just five or so years after writing those words. It was precisely this type of experience that Edith wanted to investigate. Within weeks of reading St. Teresa’s *Life*, she wrote to her friend Roman Ingarden, “At home, I have started a treatise on the philosophy of religion. I do not know what will come of it. Presumably, in the future, I will work only in this area.”³ Two months later she wrote again to Ingarden, a letter dated on the feast of St. Teresa, and told him that she intended to become Catholic: “I have not written to you about what led me to this. Actually, it is very difficult to say and I certainly cannot write about it. In any case, in recent years, I have lived very much more than I have philosophized. My works are all expressions of what has occupied me in life because the way I am now, I just have to reflect over it all.”⁴

We cannot know with certainty the exact nature of this change that came about in the summer of 1921. But given this last statement, I don’t believe she experienced merely an intellectual conversion. Rather, I think she experienced an actual grace, given to her by God and bestowed because of her seeking after the nature of religious experience. Perhaps (and this is merely imaginative speculation) she even doubted St. Teresa’s mystical experience and thus the prayer of St. Teresa was answered in St. Teresa Benedicta: “I beg Him in His goodness to give a taste of this love to anyone who thinks I am lying.”⁵

The Latin verb *transverbero* means to pierce through. And in a more ordinary way, is this not what God does to us in conversion? He pierces through our darkness and fills us with light. Nineteen years after her conversion, in 1940, Edith Stein, now *Sister Teresa Benedicta of the Cross*, wrote the following double sonnet on the occasion of this feast of Our Holy Mother’s Transverberation. I hypothesize that her composition was inspired both by St. Teresa’s mystical experience as well as her own experience of God piercing through her life in 1921:

From Heaven’s heights a beam of light here flashes,
He came into the dark depths of my heart,
The soul was wounded by Love’s flaming dart,
Which penetrated all my limbs like lashes.

Transformed since then is my entire being.
Am I no more the same one that I was?
That light has cleared away the dark, because
I am like one who was once blind now seeing.

Deep under me in unsubstantial distance,
I see the world and all the rage of its states,
Its buzzing noise does not reach me in this place.

Eternal stars glow over my existence,
And wondrously a bow of peace radiates,
A gentle sign of God’s great mercy and grace.

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The ray of heaven’s light allows me rest not,
Thus what is lighted must become a light.
The Light eternal sends me to earth’s plight:
And so I turn to bear the world now so fraught.

The love of God within my heart burns so deep,
It gladly set the world in whole aflame.
That love is homeless and attracts no fame,
This causes pain and makes the faithful soul weep.

It loves to let the golden stars shine brightly
Into the deepest depths of earth’s darkest vale,
With gentle light to penetrate the dark night.

It wants to join both Heav’n and earth so tightly,
And carry by the Holy Spirit’s strong gale
The world aloft upon His wings into light.⁶

Dear Sister, today you have been clothed in the Holy Habit of Our Holy Mother St. Teresa. In this vocation, I pray you will tread along the path taken by both St. Teresa and St. Teresa Benedicta. And while you may not experience the extraordinary mystical graces freely given to them by God, I pray that you will find in the depths of your soul this mysterious light. As St. Teresa Benedicta expresses in this sonnet, the love of God, as it is directed in your life, will cause you pain due to His homelessness in the world. But may He always find a home in

you. This is what Jesus instructs us in the Gospel today: “Whoever loves me will keep my word, and my Father will love him, and we will come to him and make our dwelling with him. . . . Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you. Not as the world gives do I give it to you. Do not let your hearts be troubled or afraid” (John 14:23, 27). Sister, this peace is given to you in this life. This is the vocation of a daughter of St. Teresa, to have your daily life pierced by the presence of God, to receive this presence in peace and then bear witness to the peace of Jesus; To be lighted by God and so be a light for this world.